
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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1

João Pedro's quality 'coming out'

João Pedro is enjoying life under Liam Rosenior. The versatile Brazil forward was excellent after coming on at half-time against West Ham. João Pedro, who has five goals in his last five games, helped [Chelsea](#) complete their comeback from 2-0 down by scoring his side's first and then creating Enzo Fernandez's stoppage-time winner. Chelsea chose well when they beat Newcastle to the signing of the 24-year-old from Brighton last summer. João Pedro was excellent at the Club World Cup, but despite dealing with fitness issues has still has 12 goals in all competitions this season. Capable of playing as either a No 9 or a No 10, the Brazilian was important for Enzo Maresca but has improved since the Italian's departure. "I've had very, very good conversations with him already, probably four in my office," Rosenior said last week. "I think he's sick of my office, where I've said to him 'If you play with intensity with your quality, the quality comes out'." **Jacob Steinberg**

Match report: [Chelsea 3-2 West Ham](#)

2

Good day for Arsenal's big guns

The spotlight had fallen firmly on the output – or lack thereof – of Arsenal's attackers in the run-up to their crucial trip to West Yorkshire. After two points from three [Premier League](#) games, the last thing Mikel Arteta needed was the loss of his most trusted forward, Bukayo Saka, in the warm-up before Saturday's clash with Leeds. But while the result alone was significant for the Gunners' title hopes, so too was the performance of three of his forwards. The man who stepped in for Saka, Noni Madueke, provided the assist for Martín Zubimendi's opener before his corner was punched into his own net by Karl Darlow. Throw in second-half goals for Viktor Gyökeres and Gabriel Jesus to round off a convincing 4-0 victory and Arteta will hope the collective seal has been ripped off his forward line's end product and that the Gunners' notorious reliance on set pieces does not need to be as critical as it has been. **Aaron Bower**

Match report: [Leeds 0-4 Arsenal](#)

3

Two different sides of Spurs

There can hardly have been a more Jekyll and Hyde display in Premier League history. But from the ruins of a wretched first half at [Tottenham Hotspur](#) Stadium, perhaps Thomas Frank learned some useful lessons. Firstly, a three-man defence may have worked against Eintracht Frankfurt in Europe but Spurs looked far more coherent when Pape Sarr came on to provide an extra body in midfield – albeit it was not ideal to lose Cristian Romero, who was feeling unwell. Xavi Simons and Dominic Solanke also gave cause for optimism in the second half. The Dutchman was scheming and driving between the lines while Solanke acted as a battering ram up front, too strong for Abdukodir Khusanov for his first goal and brilliantly inventive for his second. It's been difficult to find positives in the Premier League for Spurs this season but Frank must use this stirring comeback as a launchpad. **Dominic Booth**

Match report: [Tottenham 2-2 Manchester City](#)

Sesko the saviour for United

Benjamin Sesko now has four goals in his last four [Manchester United](#) appearances, his 94th-minute game-clincher against Fulham the best yet, giving Michael Carrick a record of three victories from his first three games in charge. "Scoring at home and scoring the winner is unbelievable," said the striker. "I've been dreaming that I can do that. I'm really happy I could help the team out and we can continue our streak now." At 22, the Slovenian should only get better. And as his strike came when entering from the bench after being benched by Carrick since the manager took over tells a tale of his spirit. **Jamie Jackson**

Improving Reds fight for Slot

"We wanted it really bad," was Dominik Szoboszlai's take on Liverpool's first league win of the year. A first comeback victory in the Premier League since last April, underlined that character and desire will be crucial to any recovery by the reigning champions as the developing rapport between Hugo Ekitiké and Florian Wirtz or the sustained excellence of Alisson. Those traits have been severely tested this season but from Ibrahima Konaté's early and rewarded return from compassionate leave to Szoboszlai's willingness to again deputise at right-back, they were faultless against Newcastle. Resources may be stretched and performances still have significant room for improvement, but there remains a fight in Arne Slot's team that bodes well for the final months of a trying campaign.

Andy Hunter

Match report: [Liverpool 4-1 Newcastle](#)

Villa appear short of options

Aston Villa racked up 27 shots in defeat against 10-man Brentford but ultimately that killer moment eluded them. Maybe Tammy Abraham's controversial disallowed goal was just that. But while Unai Emery's side pushed for an equaliser, the Villa manager was unable to turn to his bench for a gear shift. Leon Bailey, recalled from Roma last month, entered at half-time but spurned Villa's best chance and the only other arrival was Harvey Elliott, for his second appearance since October, who Emery has made plain has no long-term future at the club. Villa, decimated by injuries in recent weeks, must now decide whether a sobering loss triggers them to trade further, having allowed Evann Guessand and Donyell Malen to depart. Emery suggested their business is complete. "We don't have a lot of possibilities or opportunities to do something to improve now," he said. "We did everything we were planning. It is completely done, I think, the transfer window for us." **Ben Fisher**

Match report: [Aston Villa 0-1 Brentford](#)

Palace look to Strand Larsen

Crystal Palace started at the City Ground without a recognised striker on the pitch and did not give the impression of scoring until Neco Williams kindly donated a penalty. Palace showed plenty of endeavour but without the creativity that would make a difference. With Jean-Philippe Mateta on his way out, Oliver Glasner needs Wolves' Jørgen Strand Larsen through the door to lead the line for the remainder of the season. The Norwegian is a different prospect to Mateta and will require a change in style to help him excel. He is a striker who thrives off delivery, lacking the physicality and speed of the Frenchman. With Brennan Johnson and Ismaila Sarr on the wings for Glasner, they potentially have the suitable components to get the best from Strand Larsen, while the signing of Evann Guessand on an initial loan from Aston Villa will further boost options for a side short on ideas in Nottingham. **Will Unwin**

Match report: [Nottingham Forest 1-1 Crystal Palace](#)

Moyes defends under-fire Hürzeler

David Moyes put in a strong defence of Fabian Hürzeler after Everton's last-gasp equaliser on Saturday but unrest is growing among Brighton supporters as their side continue to struggle under their German head coach. Brighton have only beaten Burnley in the Premier League since the end of November and many have questioned whether Hürzeler deserves a third season at the helm. He is understood to still have the support of the club's hierarchy and Moyes warned that his recent experiences at West Ham showed that continuity is often better than change. "He's been unbelievable. He's done a brilliant job for Brighton," said Moyes. "I've been in a couple of places recently where sometimes the grass isn't always greener and you have to make sure that the manager is doing a really good job." **Ed Aarons**

Match report: [Brighton 1-1 Everton](#)

Rayan is Bournemouth's latest gem

Rayan, Bournemouth's arrival from Vasco da Gama, has been likened to Neymar and Vinícius Júnior but the frequent comparison has been to Adriano, Brazil's striker of the 2000s. Adriano served as an able deputy – and often partner – for the original Ronaldo in the *Seleção* but at Molineux, Rayan was fielded off the wing after coming on as a substitute. As Wolves pushed for an equaliser, the teenager's free, direct running became his new team's best hope of sealing victory. So it proved with Rayan's 90th-minute assist for Alex Scott. As cameos go, this was highly impressive. The hype will intensify if Rayan impresses again when Aston Villa visit next weekend. "He needs more information, more learning about what we need from him," said Andoni Iraola. Yet again, [Bournemouth](#) have signed a player the elite will soon enough covet, with the same going for Eli Junior Kroupi, scorer of Bournemouth's excellent first goal. **John Brewin**

Match report: [Wolves 0-2 Bournemouth](#)

Guardiola anguish at City failings

There was a reticence to Pep Guardiola when asked to voice his opinion on [a possible foul on Marc Guéhi](#) in the buildup to Dominic Solanke's first goal being overlooked by the officials. The City head coach was less reluctant, however, when it came to analysing his side's second-half failings as they allowed "a game of transitions" to unfold at Spurs. That played into the home side's hands. It is becoming a common gripe for City this season. They saw something similar in the Manchester derby a fortnight ago when they were decimated on the counterattack. City's vulnerability in such moments could prove the difference in the title race. As well as being six points behind Arsenal, City have conceded six more goals than the Gunners, far more adept at dealing with counterattacking teams. **DB**

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	24	29	53
2	Man City	24	26	47
3	Aston Villa	24	9	46
4	Man Utd	24	8	41
5	Chelsea	24	15	40
6	Liverpool	24	6	39
7	Brentford	24	4	36
8	Fulham	24	-1	34
9	Everton	24	-1	34
10	Newcastle	24	0	33

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
11	Sunderland	23	-2	33
12	AFC Bournemouth	24	-3	33
13	Brighton	24	2	31
14	Tottenham Hotspur	24	2	29
15	Crystal Palace	24	-4	29
16	Leeds	24	-11	26
17	Nottm Forest	24	-11	26
18	West Ham	24	-19	20
19	Burnley	23	-19	15
20	Wolverhampton	24	-30	8

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